Skillful Means: Tips for White People to Call in Other White People

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Stay rooted in fierce compassion for self and other. Fierce compassion includes strength, courage and empowerment, sometimes with the energy of anger, in addition to nurturing, connecting and validating aspects. We are not calling in another white person because we are "better" than they are (or more "woke"), but in an effort to address harm that they are causing to others and to themselves. For further discussion of fierce compassion, please see The Near and Far Enemies of Fierce Compassion.

If BIPOC are present, do not speak "for" them or put them on the spot. You are not intervening on their "behalf," but out of your own responsibility as a white person disrupting the enactment of white supremacy.

Begin by joining rather than othering, e.g.,

- Begin by acknowledging something positive. It can be as simple as "I'm so glad you raised this. I'm sure there are others thinking something similar." Or, you might acknowledge a positive motivation (intent), for example: "I can see you were trying to make a connection…," before addressing impact.
- Speak from a position of empathy, trying to identify and acknowledge the person's feeling and the associated need/value. "I wonder if you are feeling uncomfortable and wanting to connect with the group."
- Speak from your own experience. Acknowledge that you've said/thought/done similar things.

Follow up and stay connected. Check in with the person whose words/actions you've challenged. Invite their feelings / feedback. Take responsibility for any unskillful behaviors on your part and also honor if the person does not want to engage further.

Consider stating your own position vs. challenging. A great opportunity to use "and" (not 'but'). The goal is dialogue, not debate.

Engage people in the spirit of curiosity. Remember, we might be making incorrect assumptions. We can simply ask, "would you be willing to tell me more about what you were thinking?"

It may be helpful to **ask permission**. "I notice I'm feeling uncomfortable with what's happening. Would you be willing to hear my thoughts on this and try to sort this out together?" Or ask if the person would be open to talking more at a later time.

Practice WAIT: Why Am I Talking? Who am I doing this for? What are my motives? Am I speaking 'for' a person of color? Am I wanting to show that I'm more enlightened? Is this useful, truthful, skillful and timely?

Pause - taking a breath, calming the reactive mind/impulses can help foster more skillful discussions.

Connect the issue at hand to Dharma practice. The purpose of practice is to benefit self AND others. We want to understand if our actions cause harm, regardless of our intent. Racism harms all of us.

Speak plainly and descriptively. Avoid vague euphemisms, attribution of motivation and judgment. Instead of "that was so racist!" or "we want everyone to be comfortable," you can say "when you said this is a safe space for everyone, I think that only applies to the white people. The POC have told us many times that they often feel uncomfortable here."

Separate the person from the action. Calling a person racist not only hurts them but may also deny that racism is not just personal but institutional. We are not static beings. Labels can box people in and are a fool-proof way to end a conversation. It also weakens your message because it's easy to poke holes in the all-or-nothing 'racist' label. Speak to the words or behavior and not the person's character.

Consider inserting a 'placeholder'. This can be a useful practice for those moments when we know something harmful is happening but we can't articulate it or are not sure if intervening in the moment is the best option. " I'm feeling uncomfortable with what just happened and am not totally clear about it. I just want to put a placeholder here and sort it out later."

Be strategic. Decide what is important to challenge and what's not. Think about strategy in particular situations. Did something significant happen that feels too important to not interrupt even if I can't do it perfectly, or is it a situation where I can wait and sort out my own reactions and decide what I do want to talk w/ the other white person about at another time?

Do not mistake the above recommendations for "Be Nice."

If you are leading a group and calling in a group member.

There are a zillion scenarios, so here are a few ideas...

- Call a pause, e.g., "there are difficult things arising, let's take a moment to Pause-Relax-Open
- Be attentive to the racial harm that has arisen and don't be distracted by the urge to make things comfortable; one of your responsibilities as group leader is to support the group to hold the pain of all members
- Be sure to acknowledge the harm experienced by the BIPOC.
- Speak with an awareness of social patterns of systemic racism, rather than reducing it to a conflict between 2 people.
- It's essential to hold the understanding that two or more very different experiences of the same event are true. Our realities are largely created by our social positioning and conditioning. Attend to impact rather than privileging intent. Arguing about what's "true" will submerge the BIPOC experience into the white dominant paradigm.
- Acknowledge white discomfort without centering it. "It can be difficult for us as white people when experiences of race-related suffering are expressed."

Use placeholders to slow things down if you realize "something" has happened, but don't really know what:

"Hmmm. Something doesn't feel right, but I don't know what it is. I may ask to come back to this"

"Ouch". Saying "Ouch" allows us to express discomfort with what is being said or done- whether we address it in the moment or later.

"Whoops"-Saying "Whoops" is a quick way to acknowledge that we've said something harmful - and we can either use it as a placeholder or as a lead in to noting what we've caught ourselves saying or doing.